A few days later, my mother was summoned to the school to be told what had been decided, and she duly walked in to see one of the senior masters while I sat in the car and awaited my fate.

She emerged 10 minutes later, in teàrs.

'They've expelled you from the boarding house for the rest of term,' she said, sobbing. 'I don't know what we are going to do now. We live so far away. You may have to go to another school.'

I remember that my main concern at the time was that someone would walk past us, in the school car park, and see my mother in this distressed state, but the scale of the punishment did surprise me.

Everything was happening so fast.

My mother was still extremely upset and Carel Kriek, one of the most widely respected teachers at Affies, was suddenly standing beside our car. He was the 1st team rugby coach, and had also coached our Under-15 cricket side; he was almost my mentor at school and he tried to calm the situation.

'Look, the decision has been made,' Dr Kriek said, 'and we must respect that, but you must not even think about moving to Waterkloof or any other school. You might soon be chosen for the 1st XV and everybody wants you to stay at Affies. We'll make a plan about your accommodation for the rest of this term.'

I felt better, and my mother managed to drive our car the short distance to the Waterkloof Glen shopping centre, although she was still crying when we parked outside the Nando's restaurant.

'Ma, please stop crying,' I said. 'Everything will be OK.'

She was obviously concerned for me, and I loved her for that, but Dr Kriek was right … we did make a plan. In the end, it was arranged that I would stay in Brooklyn with the family of my father's sister, Suzanne. She had married Jurie van der Walt, a former hurdles champion, and they welcomed me into their home. Riaan, their son and my cousin, was also at Affies and, each and every day, we took a bus to and from school together.